

mountains, temperatures are moderate to cool. Spain heats up in July and August, but it's cold—or at least too cold for Vicki and me—the rest of the year. Before you visit a country, choose the right season for you.

Second, we try to avoid crowds. Since most tourists seem to detest the hot weather we like so much, we rarely have to fight for hotel rooms, seats on planes, or to get into restaurants. Most tourists visit Seville, Spain, for example, in the cool months of May and June. We avoid the crowds by going in August, when it's hot. Similarly, we go to the Yucatán in July, during the hot, sticky, rainy season. Humidity is good for us and good for our bodies. When we go, it seems we're the only tourists there to enjoy it.

Finally, the countries we visited have weak currencies. You'll find it hard to spend as much as \$50 a day. Don't worry about it, though. You'll bring your average back up the next time you go to Oslo, Geneva, or Washington, D.C.

ARGENTINA

Buenos Aires is an urban sprawl of some 9 million people. The city's opera, ballet, music, art, and theater keep us entertained. Buses, taxis, trains, and sturdy walking shoes get us around town or across the country; a car, in our view, is a senseless bother. We enjoy high-quality meat and poultry, milk and cheese, bread and pasta, and local beer and wine. Health standards compare to the world's best.

Every year Gallup takes a worldwide poll on optimism. The question is, "Do you think next year is going to be better than the one you just had?" Only Caesar knows why Gallup or anyone else wants to know such a thing. You'd think they'd focus on important issues: whether softness or absorbency sells toilet paper; whether we want our toothpaste to fight cavities, freshen our breath, brighten our smile, polish our fillings, massage our gums, or, I suppose, protect our gold-plated toothbrush.

But Gallup really does check on optimism every year. And